searching or Ambedkar's revolutionary denunciation". Savarkar's critique of caste—and it was a severe and trenchant critique—is underwritten by the premise of the need for Hindus to unite against Muslims. For him, therefore, Hindus had to become a single 'meta category' for which caste would necessarily have to be jettisoned. Much the same logic applied to Savarkar's denunciation of Hindu veneration of the cow, of ritual and Vedic chants and prayers. What mattered to him was the nation and since caste or religious dogma and prejudice excluded some Hindus from its fold, they were attacked and rejected.

The great merit of Bakhle's work is its very detailed immersion in Savarkar's poetry in Marathi and his historical works. Immediately after Partition and Independence, suspicion of involvement in Gandhi's assassination "brought complete ostracisation and drove Savarkar into virtual isolation for the rest of his life" till his death in 1966. Yet he retained a core constituency of admirers and, from the 1990s onwards, his ideological position acquired a new traction and strength. Those wanting to know how this happened, his long afterlife and what gave Savarkar's writings their appeal, will find much meat in this book. ■

–T.C.A. Raghavan

BOOKS

Man of Many Ideas

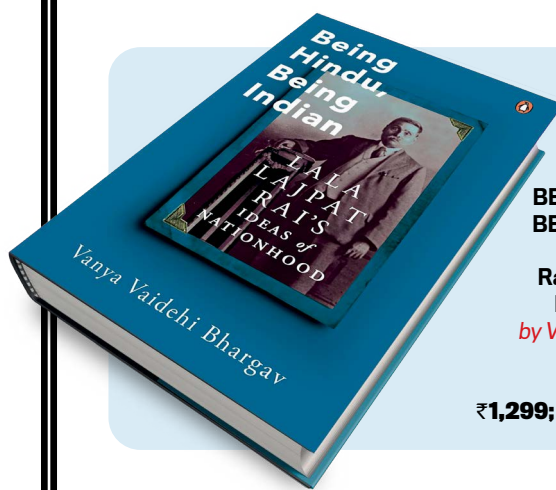
Vanya Vaidehi Bhargav questions simplistic notions of Lala Lajpat Rai's politics in this well-researched book

This is a spirited book, using prodigious amounts of research and an accessible writing style to argue a case for Lala Lajpat Rai. The resurrection of Rai follows a trend where critical research on the nationalist right wing is breaking new ground. Historians have usually associated Rai's politics with a unitary nationalism that was exclusivist. The author questions this simplistic interpretation. When Rai succumbed to a lathi charge by the colonial police in 1928, questions about subjecthood and citizenship had not been resolved. Staunch nationalists like him were still working on the range of choices between democratic principles based on individual rights and collective community sentiments, testing and strategising the possibilities of moving from one to the other or combining both.

As the title of the book provocatively makes clear, Rai's career challenges established conventions of understanding nationhood. It was not just religious minorities but also the majority Hindus who had to work out the question of belonging and nationality. Despite Rai's commitment to Hindu political organisations like the Arya Samaj and Hindu Mahasabha, no consistent connection with Hindutva ideologue Vinayak Savarkar can be established, argues the author, nor a lineage with the present-day right-wing politics that has noisily claimed him as a forebear. Rai's model of the Indian nation grappled with agnostic forms of nationhood and his rejection of a nation based on communities of faith cut both ways. It dismissed the two-nation theory but envisaged reservation for Indian Muslims. He also abandoned the reformist and theological version of modern Hinduism espoused by the Arya Samaj as it had no place for the catholicity of Hindu sects.

Although this book primarily addresses the history of ideas and political thought in modern India, the biographical details are fascinating and show the many paradoxes in Lajpat Rai's career. Rai was a product of Islamicate North India yet, on the language question, he passed over Urdu for Hindi. The influence of his early upbringing persisted, however, and showed in his political choices. As a young activist, Rai was devastated when Dayanand Saraswati passed away in 1883. Despite the emphasis on religion in Saraswati's thought, Rai chose to work with desacralised categories of 'history' and 'culture'. Although a vegetarian, he refused to support dietary restrictions within the Samaj. He wrote a passionate critique of Syed Ahmed Khan's rejection of the elective principle espoused by the Congress. In 1909, when Madan Mohan Malviya was Congress president in Lahore, he stayed away differing on the acceptance of separate electorates, but later toyed with the idea of federated 'nations'. He supported the Khilafat Movement, but after the Kohat riots in 1924, worked to strengthen the Mahasabha. The author argues that Rai's public life offered the possibility of a secularised right wing in Indian politics, a nuanced overview of which is long overdue. ■

–Partho Datta



BEING HINDU, BEING INDIAN
Lala Lajpat Rai's Ideas of Nationhood
by Vanya Vaidehi Bhargav
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